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Newsom signs Silicon Valley lawmakers' bills to combat ICE

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While federal immigration agents have stoked fear in Silicon Valley, California has passed a number of bills to keep them and those who run detention centers accountable.

Gov. Gavin Newsom on Sept. 29 signed nearly two dozen bills, with some spearheaded by Silicon Valley lawmakers to protect immigrants from U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement (ICE) that include banning shock gloves and taxing detention center operators.

"California is deploying every tool possible to stop ICE's mass detention campaign,"Assemblymember Alex Lee, who represents North San Jose, Milpitas, Fremont, Newark and Sunol, told San José Spotlight. "As ICE arms their poorly trained agents with electric shock gloves to abduct and terrorize people, we are stepping up to protect Californians by banning law enforcement's use of these dangerous weapons."

Lee and Assemblymember Ash Kalra, who represents East San Jose and South County, co-authored Assembly Bill 1633, which imposes a 25% tax on private detention center operators starting July 1, 2028. The money would be used to fund immigration services.

"While private prison operators make hundreds of thousands of dollars from imprisoning people without any regard for human dignity, AB 1633 reins in their record profits and invests directly back into immigrant services," Lee said. "We will continue to do everything we can to hold ICE and the for-profit private prison industry accountable."

Lee said on average more than 6,000 people are detained in California's privately-run detention facilities. These ICE detention facilities have been rife with alleged human rights violations and reports of inhumane living conditions, sexual abuse, unsanitary food and inadequate medical care.

September 15, 2026

ICE observer sues after being handcuffed in San Jose

September 14, 2026

Judge orders pause on work at South County ICE facility

July 18, 2026

Santa Clara County immigrant network evolved into powerhouse

More than 50 people have died in ICE detention centers during President Donald Trump's second administration, the highest level of deaths in at least a decade.

Senate Bill 942 — also known as the Civil Detainee Bill of Rights Act — aims to give immigrants held in detention rights to humane care, safe living conditions and healthy food. It is co-authored by Kalra and state Sen. Dave Cortese.

"I'm glad we were able to pass many pieces of important legislation to hold ICE accountable in California and protect vulnerable communities," Kalra previously told San José Spotlight. "My committee worked on SB 942, which is the nation's first Detainee Bill of Rights, and will enforce much-needed safety and dignity standards for those held

in immigration detention."

Two of the largest private prison companies, CoreCivic and The GeoGroup, are the major operators running ICE detention centers. CoreCivic runs two detention centers in California — the nearly 2,000-bed Otay Mesa Detention Center in San Diego County and the 2,560-bed California City Detention Facility in Kern County.

The GeoGroup runs five ICE detention facilities in the state — the 1,940-bed Adelanto ICE Processing Center in San Bernardino County, the 750-bed Desert View Annex in San Bernardino County (run alongside the Adelanto facility), the 400-bed Mesa Verde ICE Processing Center in Bakersfield, the 700-bed Central Valley Annex in Kern County and the 700-bed Golden State Annex in Kern County.

Multiple bills also aim to address how ICE agents have largely acted with impunity during raids and arrests.

Since 2025, federal immigration officers have shot at least 23 people and killed six during immigration enforcement operations, including three U.S. citizens.

While mass enforcement actions like the federal deployment in Los Angeles and Minneapolis, Minnesota haven't occurred in Santa Clara County, the region is one of the most impacted areas for targeted ICE operations, according to the Services, Immigrant Rights and Education Network. The organization is part of the Rapid Response Network of Santa Clara County, a group of volunteers that documents ICE activity, sends alerts to residents and provides free emergency legal support for immigrants.

Since the start of 2025 to June 2026, 232 Santa Clara County residents have been detained by federal immigration agents, according to the network.

Senate Bill 747, the No Kings Act, led by state Sen. Scott Wiener of San Francisco, will allow people to sue ICE for constitutional violations. Assembly Bill 1806, spearheaded by Southern California Assemblymember Jesse Gabriel, requires the state attorney general to investigate killings of unarmed residents by immigration agents. Senate Bill 873, co-authored by Kalra, will prevent arrests by ICE at courthouses.

Assembly Bill 2465, spearheaded by Lee, was vetoed. The bill would have ensured ICE contractors do not get government grants or loans.

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